



YOU ARE **38 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**
10 days to go...

YOUR BABY TODAY

Your baby's neck muscles have strengthened, so the head can be held well away from the chest wall. Once delivered, though, the buoyancy provided by the amniotic fluid will be lost and you will need to support the head at all times while holding your baby.

“ Could your baby be dreaming already? A lot of their movements are occurring when they're fast asleep. ”

Your baby has been practicing breathing since week 10, but now the pattern has changed from short practice bursts lasting 10 seconds or so, to a regular rhythmic breathing pattern of approximately 40 breaths per minute, just as the baby will breathe after birth.

Eye movements have also matured with periods of rapid eye movement (REM) lasting for just over 25 minutes at a time and rest periods lasting just under 25 minutes. REM sleep is closely coupled with periods of increased activity and a faster heart rate. So just because your baby is moving it doesn't always mean that they're awake.

Although your baby cannot stretch out as freely now, movements at least 10 times a day should continue in the same familiar pattern.

FUEL FOR LABOR

Labor is definitely tiring and thirsty work! Thankfully, it is now accepted that unless a woman is known to need anesthesia, she can eat and drink in the early stages of labor. Having said that, many women find that they don't have much of an appetite as labor progresses.

Try isotonic sports drinks, as well as drinking water, since they provide some energy to counter the fatigue of labor. It is better to sip drinks during labor instead of drinking large amounts at a time. Pack healthy snacks and drinks in your hospital bag (see [Items for your hospital bag](#)).

ASK A DOCTOR

What is “stripping the membranes” and could I have this instead of being induced if I end up being overdue? Depending on your health and the baby's condition, and many other factors (for example, you're more than 42 weeks along, you have high blood pressure, you have an infection), your doctor may induce labor. There are many ways to do this, including stripping the membranes. With a gloved finger, your doctor checks your cervix and sweeps her finger over the membranes that connect the amniotic sac and the uterine wall. The goal of this is to stimulate the release of hormones that may start labor contractions. Although this procedure may feel